We appear to have no chance of winning but, under the guidance of Mr Swart, we have trained hard, and were still hardened by the training we endured with Mr du Plessis, our Under-9 coach, who told us to dive on our rugby field full of thorns, get up, sprint and then dive among the thorns again. Above all, with Chris at hooker, Stof at flank, me at scrum-half and Skippy at inside centre, we have a special plan.

The plan is called 'Quicksports' and, in our young minds, it is pure rugby genius.

I feed the ball into the scrum. Chris hooks the ball, flanker Stof takes the ball at the back of the scrum and runs straight at the orange fly-half. Just before he reaches him he flips a soft pass to me on his outside. I throw a dummy pass to my inside centre Skippy, cut inside and run through to score the try beneath the posts.

The move works perfectly in practice, and it works perfectly against Pietersburg East. 'Quicksports' yields our first try in what becomes a convincing victory – in our minds at least, the most sensational result in all the history of Rugby Union at Warmbaths Primary School. Many of the players' parents have driven to support the team in the far-northern town, and they are thrilled. Can life, we wonder, get any better than this?

Other memories do fade, strangely. We might have lost the final 24–0 to Pietersburg South Primary School. I do not precisely recall. It may have been a windy day with every bounce of the ball on a rock-hard field going against us, but I don't exactly remember. It is the vivid recollection of the semifinal that endures.

The four of us are back in the playground at break, and we have got hold of a cherry bomb, a spherical firework, and we are collectively yielding to the temptation of making some noise.

'I'm not sure that's a great idea,' says Chris.

'Come on, man,' the rest of us say, in unison. 'It'll be fun. Just do it.'

Chris is brave bordering on gullible, and he is eventually persuaded to place the cherry bomb in the corner of the playground, to strike a match